HOW TO SAVE AJANTA

Existing plans focus on sites in isolation. What needs to be done is to bring all related sites into a composite strategy that integrates all needs–tourism, conservation, research

Treat the entire Indian Rock-Cut Architecture ecosystem of 1,200-odd sites as a 'Heritage Collective', with a unified management authority, and Ajanta as its nodal centre. Unesco often treats clusters as a continuum, e.g. Cambodia's Angkor Archaeological Park, or its 121 'Cultural Landscapes'

The primary caretakers (ASI, MTDC) must answer to a larger monitoring structure—comprising an inter-disciplinary panel of experts, scientists, representatives of Unesco, funders et al—with at least bi-annual in situ reviews, scientific surveys, updated conservation strategies

Other sites face neglect due to the near-exclusive focus on World Heritage Sites, which soak up all the tourism load and resources. The missing dwarapala at Pitalkhora and the orphaned burnt-brick monastery remains at Ajanta attest to a massive asymmetry of attention. A composite plan benefits all

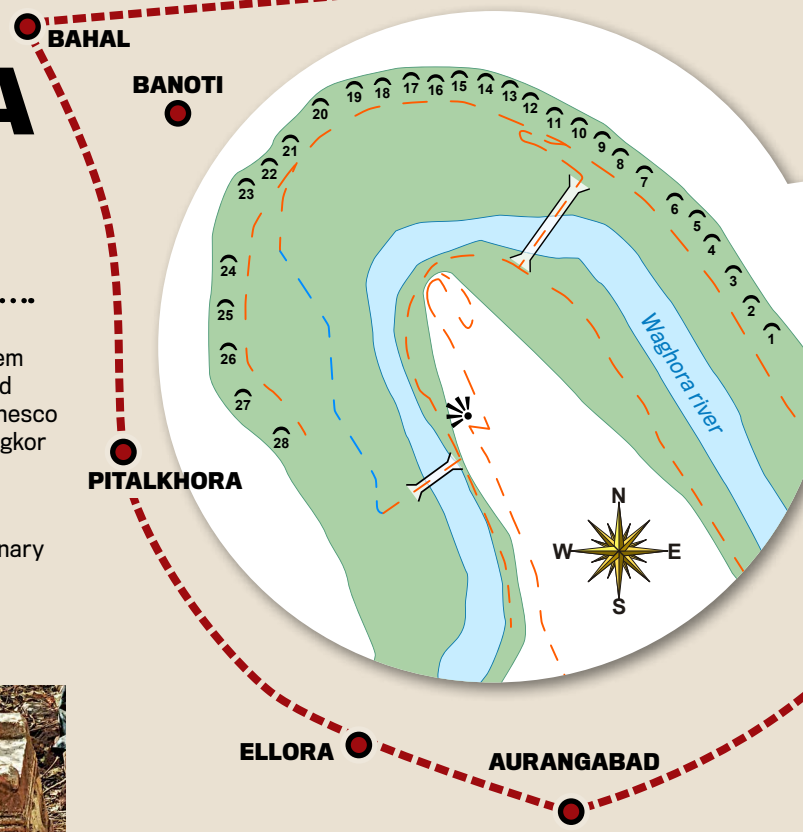


Burnt-brick monastery





Pitalkhora before and after



Unlike Ellora, only half-hour from the nearest airport, Ajanta is 100 km away—and has minimal hospitality presence. This creates a pattern of day tourists from Aurangabad, leaving little chance for either immersive tourism or vitalising the local economy



Reimagine the zone as a nucleus: hosting a modern archaeology university, heritage-compatible hospitality and a full 'heritage and nature circuit' integrating isolated but nearby sites such as Ghatotkacha, Pitalkhora, Banoti

HOW THE WORLD DOES IT

Lascaux, France (**1**), Altamira, Spain (**2**) and Mogao, China (**3**), use replicas/ visitor centres (VCs) to divert tourists entirely or substantially. Milan's Santa Maria delle Grazie, which hosts Da Vinci's *Last Supper* mural (**4**), allows only 30 people at a time. Japan's Horyuji temple murals (**5**) mostly stay under lock and key. The Ajanta VC (**6**) must be made a compulsory element to regulate circulation of footfalls, with electronically generated time slots.

